

KWS/DG/223

18TH December 2018

The President
Harvard University
Cambridge, Massachusetts 02138,
USA

Attention: Admissions Office

Dear *Sir*

RE: RECOMMENDATION FOR SWAIB OUMA OKITA

It is my great pleasure to recommend Swaib Okita, our most outstanding associate volunteer. His contribution to the wildlife ecosystem through the Kenya Wildlife Service for the last four years is commendable. The Kenya Wildlife Service is a government institution established in 1989 and tasked with the mandate to conserve and manage wildlife in Kenya, and to enforce related laws and regulations. I first interacted with Swaib after his near-tragic experience in 2013, when he was almost trampled and killed by an elephant, Sally, in Samburu national reserve. Rather than being intimidated by this, he was inspired to valiantly dive into conservation matters and has been fully dedicated to preservation of wildlife since then.

Upon the death of Sally in the cruel hands of poachers, Swaib was challenged to take action against the menace that had greatly reduced the elephant population. He organized 10-kilometer walks across 25 of the 47 counties in the country all in Sally's memory. This caught the attention of some of our key partners such as the World Wide Fund for Nature (WWF), Save The Elephants (STE) and the International Fund for Animal Welfare (IFAW), who aided in funding the campaign. Consequently, we raised an astonishing 34100 USD that went into starting the Sally Elephant Sanctuary in Samburu national reserve. In fact, this campaign gained so much traction that years later, the picture of the elephant Sally is the one being used as the face of the new Kenyan currency.

Swaib further volunteered, through his software company(www.treob.co.ke), to be a part of the team that is reinventing our wildlife monitoring and tagging system. This new system will contribute to improve our wildlife monitoring and help in reducing poaching incidences.

One of the challenges we face is aggravated human-wildlife conflicts that sometimes cause untold losses of property and human and wildlife lives. Following one of such conflicts, Swaib accompanied our peacekeeping troops to Marsabit, a small town in Northern Kenya. On coming back, he wrote an elaborate well-researched proposal on the benefits of implementing chili and beehive fences as an addition to our moats and electrical fences. Such fences are particularly beneficial as they keep wildlife on their side while supplying the surrounding communities with food products and for some, a source of livelihood. His proposal has since been implemented in 63% of our wildlife parks and has reduced cases of human-wildlife conflicts by 80%. This creative approach to problem solving distinguishes him from the rest.

Seeking to expand his horizons, Swaib attempted to tour every park in the country. It was during one of these mind-blowing visits to Malindi Marine park that he noticed a potential gap that if well exploited could generate more income for the organization. He suggested that we introduce camping sites along the shores of our marine parks. This has become very popular and it's the fourth largest revenue earner for the organization. We adopted this approach to some of our inland parks that contain lakes and/or are crossed by great rivers such as the Lake Nakuru national park. The project has especially been very successful in the aforementioned park where it has raised awareness of the rare bird species that dwell around the lake. This has immensely contributed to the increase in tourist numbers.

Swaib's interest in wildlife conservation, combined with his stellar writing skills, has led him to write avidly on matters of wildlife. Some of his articles have been featured in the KWS blog, local magazines and his blog (www.artsiva.com). This caught the eye of his former principal at Alliance High School. Using this as a stepping stone, Swaib convinced him to take a group of fifty students who were top of their class to Tsavo East Education Center where they learnt widely about wildlife and conservation. A group of these students were deeply intrigued and, under Swaib's guidance, devoted their time to create educational posters and paintings revolving around conservation. These were showcased in our stand at the largest annual trade fair in Nairobi. I loved how Swaib was at the forefront of sensitizing everyone who attended the event on conservation, more so on the plight of endangered species. His drive and ambition really stood out.

He has recently started a campaign christened "adopt a Christmas Tree" to plant at least one thousand trees in his residential estate which happens to neighbor Nairobi National Park. Kenya Wildlife Service encourages increase of wildlife spaces, healthy habitats and human-wildlife co-existence. His project will contribute enormously to increasing habitats for primates that roam the neighborhood of Nairobi National Park.

For all his diligent efforts, Swaib earned an honorary mention from the President of the Republic during Kenya's 55th Jamhuri Day celebrations. I was more than happy to see him recognized in this way. It has been an absolute honor working with such a great mind. Without a shadow of a doubt, he will be a most valuable addition to your student body.

Yours Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, consisting of a large, stylized 'M' followed by a long horizontal stroke that curves upwards at the end.

DIRECTOR
KENYA WILDLIFE SERVICE
P. O. Box 40241,
NAIROBI.

Dr Charles Musyoki, PhD., OGW.
Ag. Director General